

THROUGH THE AGES

Military service

Despite stories of brave heroines entering combat throughout history, formal enlistment for women into combat roles is a modern phenomenon. Even today, many countries do not allow women to serve as combatants.



▲ Soviet advance

The Woman's Battalion of Death marches during the Russian Revolution of 1917 (see pp. 214–217). The number of women in the Red Army swelled hugely from 1917 to 1920.

THE AGE OF MODERN WARFARE (dating to the outset of World War I) has drastically changed women's roles within the military. Modern warfare, categorized as warfare which uses modern technology and strategy, has seen a move away from pitched battles to a “total” approach to conflict in which civilian infrastructure is regarded as a legitimate military target.

While women have a long history serving in auxiliary military positions—for example as nurses, drivers, and secretaries—in the 20th and 21st centuries, many barriers preventing women from serving in combat roles have

“I was **trained** to **do what I did**, and I did it. We all **lived** through that **battle**.”

SGT. LEIGH ANN HESTER, 2011

fallen, meaning that instances of female soldiers are no longer exceptional. In Eastern Europe, women have served as combatants since the 19th century. In Hungary, a woman served as an “order guard” in the independence war of 1868 (see pp. 130–133). Increasingly, nations are allowing women into their combat ranks and women are serving within all positions of the military. Today, all of Scandinavia, much of Eastern Europe, France, Germany, the Netherlands, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand allow women to serve in combat positions, as do Israel, Eritrea, and North Korea. The US also lifted their previous combat ban for women in 2013.

Challenges of combat

Women in combat face both physical and psychological challenges. Many soldiers and civilians believe that women should not be given combat roles—citing their supposed physical inferiority and “emotional” state of